



Book Interview Reference Guide

For Read for Rewards — Comprehension Interview



ANIMAL FARM

Author: George Orwell | **Published:** 1945 | **Type:** Allegorical novella

What It's About (1 sentence)

Animals on a farm overthrow their human owner to create an equal society, but the pigs gradually take over and become just as bad — or worse — than the humans they replaced.

Key Characters

Character	Who They Are	What They Represent
Old Major	Elderly pig who inspires the rebellion with a speech about animal freedom	The idealist / founder of the revolution (Marx/Lenin)
Napoleon	Pig who seizes power after the rebellion; becomes dictator	Corrupt leader who uses power for himself (Stalin)
Snowball	Pig who rivals Napoleon; intelligent, wants to improve the farm	The idealistic leader driven out (Trotsky)
Squealer	Pig who spreads propaganda; convinces animals everything is fine	The media / propaganda machine
Boxer	Strong, loyal horse. Motto: "I will work harder"	The hardworking common people exploited by leaders
Benjamin	Old donkey; cynical, sees through the pigs but says nothing	People who see injustice but stay silent
The Dogs	Napoleon's personal guards, raised from puppies to be loyal to him	Secret police / enforcers
Mr. Jones	The original farmer; drunk, neglects the animals	The old corrupt ruler overthrown
The Sheep	Mindlessly repeat slogans ("Four legs good, two legs bad")	People who follow without thinking

Plot Summary (Key Events)

1. **Old Major's Speech** — Inspires animals to dream of freedom and equality
2. **The Rebellion** — Animals drive Mr. Jones off the farm; rename it "Animal Farm"
3. **Seven Commandments** — Written on the barn wall (e.g., "All animals are equal")
4. **Power Struggle** — Napoleon drives Snowball off the farm using the dogs
5. **Gradual Corruption** — Pigs start sleeping in beds, drinking alcohol, changing the commandments
6. **Boxer's Betrayal** — When Boxer gets injured, Napoleon sells him to a glue factory (tells animals it's a hospital)
7. **Final Scene** — Pigs walk on two legs, wear clothes, dine with humans. Animals look from pig to man and "cannot tell which is which"

The Seven Commandments (and How They Change)

Original	Changed To
No animal shall sleep in a bed	"...with <i>sheets</i> "
No animal shall drink alcohol	"...to <i>excess</i> "
No animal shall kill any other animal	"...without <i>cause</i> "
All animals are equal	"...but some animals are more equal than others"

Major Themes

- **Power corrupts** — Those who gain power gradually abuse it
- **Propaganda & manipulation** — Language is used to control (Squealer constantly rewrites history)
- **Blind obedience** — The sheep and Boxer follow without questioning
- **The danger of apathy** — Benjamin sees the truth but does nothing
- **Ideals vs. reality** — The revolution's principles get twisted to serve the powerful
- **History repeats** — The pigs become indistinguishable from the humans they replaced

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS — ANIMAL FARM

Basic Comprehension:

- Why did the animals rebel against Mr. Jones?
- What were the Seven Commandments? Can you name a few?
- What happened to Snowball? Why?
- What happened to Boxer at the end?

Understanding Themes:

- How did the pigs change the commandments, and why did the other animals accept it?
- What does Squealer represent? How does he keep the animals in line?
- Why didn't Benjamin speak up even though he could see what was happening?
- What's the meaning of the last line — that you can't tell the pigs from the humans?

Deeper / Opinion:

- Do you think the rebellion was worth it? Why or why not?
- Which character would you be, and why?
- Can you think of a real-life situation where something like this happened — leaders who started with good intentions but became corrupt?
- What could the animals have done differently to prevent Napoleon from taking over?
- What lesson does this book teach about leadership and power?

"All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others."

"The creatures outside looked from pig to man, and from man to pig... but already it was impossible to say which was which."

THE RUTHLESS ELIMINATION OF HURRY

Author: John Mark Comer | **Published:** 2019 | **Type:** Christian non-fiction / spiritual formation

What It's About (1 sentence)

A pastor shares how "hurry" — not just busyness but a deep inner rush — is the greatest enemy of the spiritual life, and offers four ancient practices from Jesus' own lifestyle to fight it.

The Core Idea

"You must ruthlessly eliminate hurry from your life... Hurry is the great enemy of spiritual life in our day. There is nothing else." — Dallas Willard to John Ortberg

This quote from Dallas Willard is the seed of the entire book. Comer's argument: **hurry and love are incompatible**. You can't love God, love people, or experience peace/joy when you're always rushing.

Book Structure

Part	Focus	Key Point
Part 1: The Problem	What hurry is and why it's destructive	Hurry is a form of violence on the soul. It kills love, joy, and peace.
Part 2: The Solution	The answer isn't more time — it's a different way of life	Follow Jesus' actual lifestyle, not just his teachings. Adopt his practices.
Part 3: Four Practices	Practical ways to "unhurry" your life	Silence & Solitude, Sabbath, Simplicity, Slowing

Part 1 — The Problem: Hurry

- **"Hurry sickness"** — a term from medicine: the constant struggle to do more in less time
- Corrie ten Boom: "If the devil can't make you sin, he'll make you busy"
- Carl Jung: "Hurry is not of the devil; hurry *is* the devil"
- Technology (especially smartphones since 2007) has made it worse — "Your phone doesn't work for you. You're not the customer; you're the product."
- **Busyness is the new status symbol** — used to be leisure showed wealth; now being "crazy busy" does

10 Symptoms of Hurry Sickness:

1. Irritability
2. Hypersensitivity
3. Restlessness
4. Workaholism / nonstop activity
5. Emotional numbness
6. Out-of-order priorities
7. Lack of care for your body
8. Escapist behavior (bingeing, scrolling, etc.)
9. Slippage of spiritual disciplines
10. Isolation

Part 2 — The Solution: Follow Jesus' Lifestyle

- The problem isn't lack of time — it's how we use it. "The solution to an overbusy life is not more time. It's to slow down and simplify around what really matters."
- **Jesus was never in a hurry.** "To walk with Jesus is to walk with a slow, unhurried pace." (Walter Adams, C.S. Lewis' spiritual director)
- Three goals of following Jesus: (1) **Be with** Jesus, (2) **Become like** Jesus, (3) **Do what he would do** if he were you
- A "**rule of life**" — a schedule and set of practices to order your life around the way of Jesus (like a trellis for a vine to grow on)

Part 3 — The Four Practices

Practice	What It Means	Key Idea
1. Silence & Solitude	Intentionally being quiet and alone with God	Jesus regularly withdrew to quiet places to pray. If <i>he</i> needed it, how much more do we?
2. Sabbath	One full day per week: stop working + delight in God/family/rest	Hebrew meaning: "to stop" AND "to delight." The only spiritual discipline God <i>commanded</i> .
3. Simplicity	Remove what distracts from what matters most	The culture says "more = better." Jesus says the opposite. Less stuff = more space for God.
4. Slowing	Physically slow your pace of life	Drive slower. Put the phone away. Take long vacations. "Slow down your body, slow down your life."

Key Quotes Worth Knowing

"Love, joy, and peace are at the heart of all Jesus is trying to grow in the soil of your life. And all three are incompatible with hurry."

"What you give your attention to is the person you become."

"An easy life isn't an option; an easy yoke is." (referencing Matthew 11:28-30)

"We find God's will for our lives in our limitations." — Peter Scazzero

"Hurry is the death of prayer and only impedes and spoils our work. It never advances it." — Walter Adams

Major Themes

- **Hurry destroys the spiritual life** — You can't hear God when you're always rushing
- **Technology is not neutral** — Phones are designed to steal your attention
- **Limitations are a gift** — Accepting what you can't do opens space for what matters
- **Jesus modeled a slower life** — He wasn't busy; he was present
- **Practices > beliefs** — What you do daily shapes who you become more than what you believe
- **Counter-cultural living** — Sabbath, simplicity, and slowing are acts of rebellion against a hurried world

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS — THE RUTHLESS ELIMINATION OF HURRY

Basic Comprehension:

- What is the main problem the book identifies? What is "hurry sickness"?
- Who said the famous quote about ruthlessly eliminating hurry?
- What are the four practices Comer recommends?
- What does "Sabbath" mean in Hebrew?

Understanding Themes:

- Why does the author say hurry and love are incompatible?
- How do smartphones and technology make the hurry problem worse?
- What does the book mean by "the solution isn't more time"?
- Why is simplicity important for fighting hurry?
- What's a "rule of life" and why does Comer think everyone needs one?

Deeper / Personal Application:

- Do you recognize any of the 10 symptoms of hurry sickness in your own life?
- Which of the four practices (Silence, Sabbath, Simplicity, Slowing) do you think would be hardest for you? Why?

- The book says "what you give your attention to is the person you become." What does that mean for how you use your phone or free time?
- How did Jesus model a non-hurried life? Can you think of examples from the Bible?
- What's one thing you could change this week to be less hurried?
- Do you agree that busyness has become a status symbol? Why?

